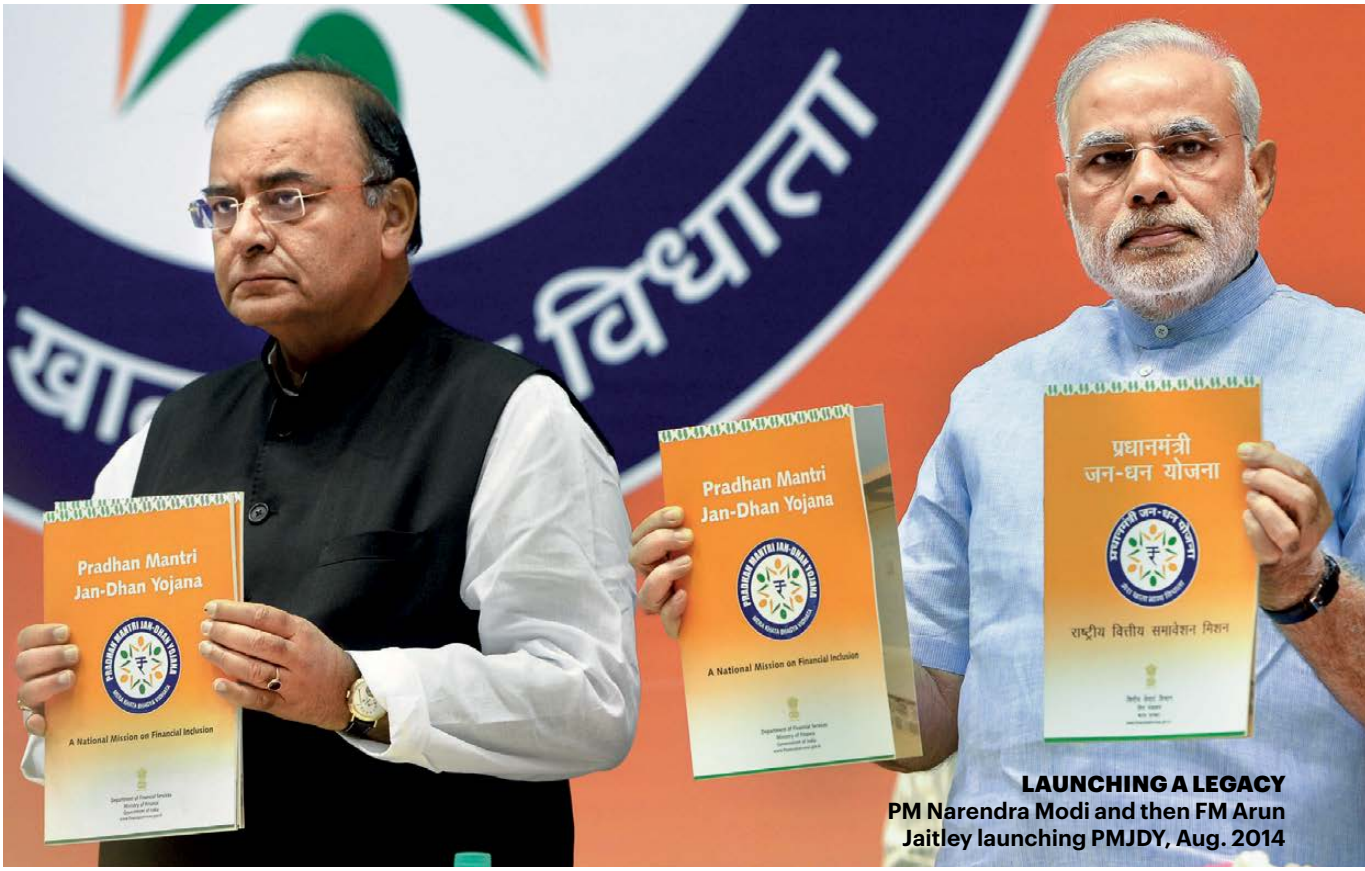


VIKRAM SHARMA

LAUNCHING A LEGACY
PM Narendra Modi and then FM Arun Jaitley launching PMJDY, Aug. 2014

49th ANNIVERSARY

TURNING POINTS
GOVERNANCE

PM JAN DHAN YOJANA, 2014

Banking the Unbanked

Ten years of PMJDY have transformed financial access for millions, empowering them to save, invest and access credit, while driving economic and social change

BY SONAL KHETARPAL

This year marks the 10th anniversary of the Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana (PMJDY), a groundbreaking initiative that brought millions of underprivileged Indians into the formal banking system. Launched in August 2014, the scheme offered zero-balance savings accounts without any minimum balance requirement, free RuPay debit cards, and essential financial security features like accident insurance of Rs 2 lakh and an overdraft facility of Rs 10,000. From its inception, PMJDY has grown exponentially. The number of accounts surged from 147.2 million in March 2015 to 531.3 million today, with deposits totalling Rs 2.31 lakh crore.

Beyond numbers, the initiative has created ripples across the economic landscape. Access to a bank account is more than a financial milestone; it's an enabler of economic independence. In fact, with the proliferation of UPI and digital payments, many of these accounts became active, as it was now safer to receive payments and accumulate savings. The average balance in PMJDY accounts rose from Rs 1,065 in 2015 to Rs 4,352 in 2024, reflecting growing trust and utility. Account holders could now leverage their financial history to secure loans, reducing reliance on predatory moneylenders. This, in turn, has increased the disposable income in their hands, which can be spent on better food, education and health—thus leading to better social outcomes.